By Savith Rallapalli (October 2026)

Recovery Despite Liquidity Constraints in PE Exits

The private equity exit market is recovering in value, but not in terms of volume. Corporate acquisitions are driving the recovery while IPOs lag, and Europe is recovering more broadly.

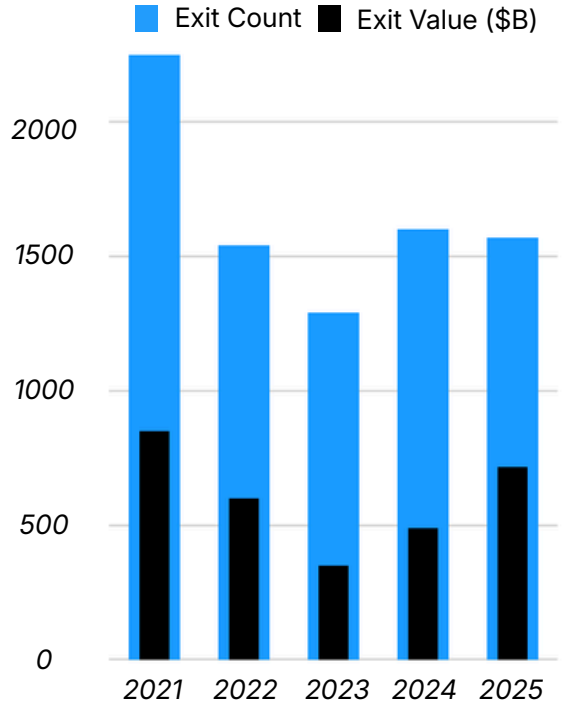
$717B[1]
Global buyout exit value, 2025
+47% vs 2024

1,570[1]
Number of PE exits in 2025
–2% vs 2024

~33,000[2]
Unsold portfolio companies
as of mid-2026

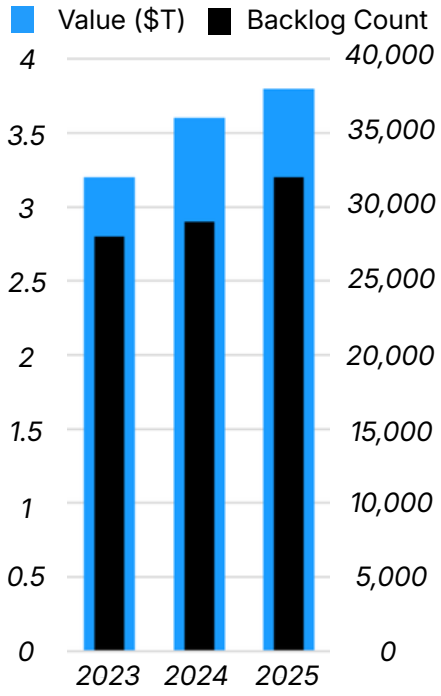
~7 years[1]
Average holding period at exit
vs 5-6 years, 2010-2021

Fewer But Larger Exits Now[1*]



Seven exits (under 0.5% of the count) worth more than $10B accounted for 22% of total exit value

Unsold Backlog Is Growing[3]



Unsold companies rose from about 28,000 to 32,000 since 2023 and their value from $3.2T to $3.8T

Corporate Buyers Are Recovering, But IPOs Have Not Returned[1]

Route	2025 Value	vs 2024	vs 2021
Corporate Buyers	~$463B	+66%	~ –4%
Sponsor-to-Sponsor	~$219B	+21%	~ –13%
IPOs	~$35B	+36%	**~ –70%**

With the IPO route still largely shut, the backlog depends on a narrow set of corporate and sponsor buyers

Europe's Exit Recovery Is Broader Than North America's[1]

Region	Corporate Buyers	Sponsor-to-Sponsor
North America	+73%	**–19%**†
Europe	+82%	**+56%**
Global	+66%	+21%

Excluding one large deal, North America's sponsor-to-sponsor value fell, leaving its rebound resting on corporate buyers

Sources:
[1] Bain & Company, Global Private Equity Report 2026 (data from: Dealogic).
[2] Bain & Company, Private Equity Midyear Report 2026.
[3] Bain & Company, Global Private Equity Report 2024, 2025, 2026; backlog figures are reported in each edition and the as-of dates vary.

Notes:
** Estimates from Bain's charts: exit value and count for 2021-2024*
~ Route values and changes are estimates read from Bain's charts.
† North America excludes the Aligned Data Centers deal whereas the global figure includes it.